PRE-PURCHASE INSPECTION CHECKLIST

Toyota Land Cruiser J20 / J25 (FJ25)

1955–1960 · FJ25 · FJ28 · F 3.9 I6

BOXYTRUCKS

CHECK BEFORE YOU BUY

- [ ] **Prove it's really a 25**
  IH8MUD's FJ25 group has seen FJ40 tubs on rebuilt frames wearing FJ25 VIN plates. Real FJ25 tells include the fuel tank under the seat, round rear wheel cut-outs, a flat floor with no hump for an offset transfer case, a centered rear differential and an FJ25-specific steering center link. Photograph the frame from underneath, especially the crossmembers and spring hangers, before you pay a 25 price.

- [ ] **Match the numbers**
  The data plate lists frame and engine numbers, and FJ25 VINs read like 9FJ25-12645L (year digit, model, serial, L for left-hand drive). Registry members note engines weren't installed in strict numerical order, but the block number should sit in the right range for the frame. Check the block stamping against the plate; Bring a Trailer listings photograph both.

- [ ] **Know where it was restored**
  Most FJ25s sold in the US recently were refurbished in Colombia, Costa Rica or elsewhere in Latin America and then imported. That's fine, but restoration quality varies. Look for cracked paint at panel joints, swapped seats and later running gear. Get the title and import paperwork in order before you pay.

- [ ] **Original engine or a 2F?**
  Swaps are common, and the market notices. In June 2025 a 2F-powered 1959 FJ25 sold on Bring a Trailer for $14,250. In July 2026 a refurbished F-powered 1959 sold there for $37,500. A later 2F head on an F block is a 'Frankencruiser' sign that IH8MUD members flag.

- [ ] **Wheels and FJ25-only parts**
  FJ25 wheels are scarce. IH8MUD members report that 15-inch disc-brake wheels hit the tie-rod ends, 15-inch drum wheels won't clear the FJ25's drum rivets, and most other 16-inch wheels have too small a center bore. Rear spring hangers and bolts, top bows and the pre-1960 toolbox lid (diagonal ribs, five catches) are FJ25-specific, so missing pieces are expensive to find.

- [ ] **Brakes and hydraulics**
  Specter Off-Road lists its FJ25 brake and clutch master-cylinder kits (1-inch bore, cast iron) as discontinued, so check that the hydraulics work before you buy. Some restored trucks have front disc conversions, which make them safer but less original.

- [ ] **Year details matter to purists**
  Owners report that 1958-and-earlier trucks (and some 1959s) use a three-bolt front-fender-to-frame pattern, that the 1959 wears the 'Thunderbird' emblem rather than the oval, and that the cradle-style front engine mount and the old toolbox lid both changed around 1960. If you're paying for originality, get the details checked by someone from the owners' group.

IS IT THE REAL THING?

- [ ] **VIN plate format**
  Owners' plates read like 9FJ25-12645L or 0-FJ25-21848: a year digit, the model code, a serial number and an L suffix for left-hand drive. The plate also lists the engine number.
- [ ] **Frame and chassis tells**
  IH8MUD members point to the under-seat fuel tank, a flat floor with no hump for an offset transfer case, round rear wheel cut-outs, a centered rear differential, FJ25-specific rear spring hangers and an FJ25 steering center link.
- [ ] **Engine numbers**
  The registry shows F engines weren't fitted in strict numerical order, but the block number should fall in the right range for the frame. A 2F head or valve cover on an F-numbered block means parts have been mixed.
- [ ] **Year details**
  Owners report three-bolt front-fender mounting on 1958-and-earlier trucks (and some 1959s), the 'Thunderbird' emblem on 1959s, and a toolbox lid with diagonal ribs and five catches that changed around 1960, about when the cradle front engine mount was dropped.

NOTES

From the full guide at https://boxytrucks.com/models/land-cruiser/fj25/, with sources. Recalls follow the VIN: check at nhtsa.gov/recalls. General information only, not a professional inspection; see boxytrucks.com/about/disclaimer/. © BoxyTrucks